to consider, it may wind up being in America's interest to help make North Korea's nukes safer. While most US strategists must draw up plans to deter and, if necessary, defeat a nuclear-armed North Korea, others should consider unorthodox ways of ensuring a safer North Korean nuclear arsenal.

Squaring that aim with credible deterrence will be difficult. For example, to make sure that Kim has constant communications with his nuclear units so that he does not fear losing contact with them, would Washington assure him that it will not sabotage North Korea's command and control capabilities, whether through cyber warfare or other means? This was suggested by a former senior US nuclear weapons officer in private conversations. Such a promise might reduce pressure on Kim and his senior officers in a crisis. Could the United States ever propose nuclear stability steps like establishing a hotline between Washington and Pyongyang? Given North Korea's closed and hostile system, such cooperation may seem impossible, but the alternative—constant suspicion and hair-trigger reactions—is more daunting.

If any nation has a possibility, no matter how small, of helping Kim keep his nukes safe, it is China, North Korea's only official ally and its major supporter. Beijing remains the only actor close enough to Pyongyang to even try to instill some nuclear responsibility, or perhaps the only one that could try to pressure the North Koreans into accepting some "best practices" in nuclear guardianship. Given how little the United States currently understands about Chinese nuclear doctrine, it is a little like trusting the fox to guard the coyotes, but Washington has few palatable options for dealing with an established North Korean nuclear state. The question is whether Beijing has any interest in helping ensure a stable nuclear operating environment in North Korea, or whether it sees ongoing US–North Korean nuclear enmity as a means of exercising greater influence over the region.

As crazy as it sounds, the Trump administration or its successors might consider reaching out to the Chinese to encourage them to offer some friendly advice to Kim. Kim undoubtedly wants to keep the details of his program as secret as possible, but Chinese president Xi